The Lighthouse Keepers

For almost two centuries the keepers of the Gray Point light climbed the same hundred and twelve steps every dusk. They trimmed wicks, polished lenses and wrote down the weather in a ledger that is still kept in the harbor office.

Early years

The first keeper, a retired ship's carpenter, built the stairs himself. He claimed that a keeper who could not whistle on the way up had no business at the top, and the rule was never written down but was always obeyed.

Supplies arrived by boat once a month. When fog closed the channel, the family lived on salted fish and oat bread until the bell on the quay was heard again.

Daily duties

Every keeper was expected to complete the same round, in this order:

- Trim and refill the lamps before sunset.
- Wind the clockwork that turns the lens.
- Record wind, tide and visibility in the ledger.
- Sound the fog signal whenever the far headland disappears.

A fuller account of the round is published by the Coastal Heritage Trust, which also keeps the oldest ledgers.

The ledgers

The ledgers survive in three bound volumes. Their pages record small events as carefully as storms, which makes them a quiet history of the coast.

1. Volume one covers the years of the first keeper.
2. Volume two covers the long peace and the wreck of the *Marigold*.
3. Volume three ends when the lamp was made automatic.

Readers who wish to return to the beginning can jump back to the first section.

Visiting

The tower is open on summer weekends. Visitors are asked to wear flat shoes and to whistle, quietly, on the stairs.